

Lesson 4: Share What You Know

Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building

What This Lesson Is About

Today you're writing the first of five short pieces of content you'll create this course — your **Content Piece #1**. This isn't a resume, and it isn't a big formal essay. It's a short, honest post or note where you teach one small, specific thing you actually learned — a tip, a lesson from a project, or a mini-tutorial.

Depending on your track, this will eventually become: - A **LinkedIn post** (if you're 16+ and using LinkedIn), or - A **Notes/Blog entry** on your portfolio site from Course 16, or - A **shared Google Doc** you can send to a teacher, mentor, or program you're applying to.

Today, you're just focused on writing it — formatting for your specific platform comes later.

Why This Matters

Here's the one rule to remember for all five content pieces:

Teach something small and specific — don't try to sound like an expert on everything.

Nobody trusts "I'm skilled in Python and problem-solving." Almost everybody trusts "I kept getting an error when someone typed a city name with a space in it, and here's the one-line fix that solved it." Specific, honest content is more convincing, more useful to readers, and — good news — much easier to write, because you already have the details. You just have to report them.

The Content Formula

Every content piece you write, all five, can follow this same three-part formula:

1. **What I was doing** — the task, project, or situation. One or two sentences.
2. **What I learned or noticed** — the specific tip, insight, or mistake-turned-lesson. Two or three sentences. This is the heart of the piece — be concrete.
3. **Why it might help someone else** — one sentence connecting your experience outward to a reader who might face the same thing.

That's it. Three parts. If all three are there, you have a complete content piece.

Worked Example: Jordan R.

Here's a fictional example from a student named Jordan, who just finished a small project building a to-do list app.

Testing your app's "empty state" actually matters

This week I built a simple to-do list app where you can add and check off tasks. It worked great — until I deleted every task and the app crashed with a blank error screen.

I learned that I had only tested my app with tasks already in the list, so I never noticed that my code assumed there would always be at least one item. The fix was one `if` statement checking whether the list was empty before trying to display it.

If you're building anything with a list — tasks, messages, search results — try emptying it out completely before you call it done. The "nothing here" case is easy to forget and easy to break.

Notice what this example does: - **Hook**: the bolded opening line pulls the reader in with a specific, useful claim, not a generic one. - **What I was doing**: one sentence, plain language, no jargon. - **What I learned**: the specific detail (an empty list crashing the app, the one-line fix) — not "I learned a lot about coding." - **Why it helps others**: a direct, actionable sentence any reader could apply. - **Takeaway**: the closing line lands the point in one sentence anyone could remember. - **Honesty**: Jordan doesn't claim to be an "expert in error handling." Jordan describes one true thing that happened.

Key Terms

Term	Meaning
Content piece	One complete short post, article, or note — the unit you're building 5 of this course.
Hook	The opening line or title that makes a reader want to keep reading — usually the most specific, concrete part of the piece stated up front.
Takeaway	The closing line that sums up the one useful point you want the reader to remember or act on.

Step-by-Step Activity: Draft Content Piece #1

1. **Pick your material.** Choose one real project, class exercise, or coding attempt from the last few weeks — big or small. It's fine if it's small.
2. **Fill in the three formula parts** using the Worksheet (What I was doing / What I learned / Why it might help someone else).
3. **Write a hook.** One sentence or short title that states your specific lesson up front.
4. **Write a takeaway.** One closing sentence that sums up the point.

5. **Assemble the draft.** Put hook → what I was doing → what I learned → why it helps → takeaway into one short piece, about 100–250 words.
6. **Run the self-check** (see Worksheet): does it sound honest and specific, or does it sound exaggerated or vague anywhere? Revise anything that doesn't pass.
7. **Save your draft** in your content-planning doc/sheet, ready for platform formatting in a later step.

Knowledge Checks

1. What are the three parts of the content formula, in order?
2. True or False: A content piece should try to make you sound like an expert in as many skills as possible.
3. Which is a stronger opening line: "I am proficient in debugging methodologies" or "My app crashed every time a user typed an extra space — here's the one-line fix"? Why?
4. Why is a small, specific mistake-and-fix often *more* convincing content than a broad claim of skill?
5. Name the two "bookend" parts of a content piece that go at the very beginning and the very end.

Reflection Prompts

1. What is one real, specific moment from your own coding work in the last few weeks that could become a content piece?
2. Think of a claim you were tempted to exaggerate in your draft. Why did you want to inflate it, and what happened when you scaled it back to the honest version?
3. Now that you've written content piece #1, what do you expect to be easier or harder about writing pieces 2–5?

Submission Instructions

- Complete the Worksheet's "Content Piece #1 Draft" template in full.
- Save your draft in your content-planning doc/sheet (the same tool you'll use to track all 5 pieces).
- Do **not** publish it publicly yet — your instructor will review the draft first.
- Bring or share your completed Worksheet, including the tracker table for all 5 planned pieces, by the deadline your instructor gives in class.